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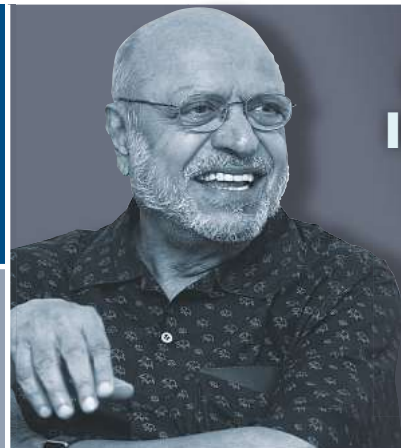
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AFP

■ People gather around a bus hit by an Israeli strike in the Mawasi area west of Khan Younis city in Gaza Strip yesterday. The death toll in the enclave has reached 45,259.

Gazans call for help as Israel hits hospital

OFFICIAL: STRIKES ON FACILITY DANGEROUS AND TERRIFYING

GAZA STRIP

Israeli forces struck one of only two functioning hospitals in northern Gaza yesterday, said an official from the facility, urging the international community to intervene before "it is too late."

Hossam Abu Safiyeh, director of Kamal Adwan hospital in the city of Beit Lahia, described the situation at the medical facility as "extremely dangerous and terrifying" owing to shelling by Israeli forces.

Safiyeh reported that the hospital, which is currently treating 91 patients, had been targeted yesterday by Israeli drones.

"This morning, drones dropped bombs in the hospital's courtyards and on its roof," said Safiyeh in a statement. "The shelling, which also destroyed nearby houses

and buildings, did not stop throughout the night."

The shelling and bombardment have caused extensive damage to the hospital, Safiyeh added.

"We face a constant threat every day. The shelling continues from all directions. The situation is extremely critical and requires urgent international intervention before it is too late," he said. On Sunday,



We face a constant threat every day. The shelling continues from all directions. The situation is extremely critical."

Hossam Abu Safiyeh
Director, Hamal Adwan hospital

Safiyeh said he received orders to evacuate the hospital, but the Israeli military denied issuing such directives. A military spokesman denied that the hospital was being targeted.

Located in Beit Lahia, the hospital is one of only two still operational in northern Gaza.

Focus of Israeli strikes

The area has been the focus of an intense air and ground campaign by Israeli forces since October 6, aimed at prevent Hamas from regrouping.

Most of the dead and injured from the offensive are brought to Kamal Adwan and Al Awda hospitals.

The United Nations and other organisations have repeatedly decried the worsening humanitarian conditions in Gaza, particularly in the north, since the latest military offensive began. —AFP

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UAE property owners eye better mortgage rates in 2025

Banks likely to aggressively promote refinancing

DUBAI

BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

UAE property owners with mortgages face a key decision for 2025: should they refinance? Recent interest rate cuts – 1 per cent in four months – offer lower fixed-rate options starting at 3.79 per cent. This especially helps those on variable-rate EMIs, whose payments soared after rate hikes since 2022.

Refinancing could lock in lower rates for 2-3 years, reducing monthly costs. However, switching costs and the current rate differential must be carefully assessed. Experts advise that owners still on fixed-rate mortgages wait, as refinancing may not be cost-effective unless rate differences exceed 75 basis points.

Those with fixed rates between 4.75 and 5.49 per cent can explore new offers, while those in the 4.24 to 4.75 per cent range might wait for further cuts. Despite lower base rates, variable mortgage pricing stays influenced by Emirates Interbank Offered Rate

(EIBOR), which reflects interbank lending rates. The experts also suggest it may take 6-12 months for the economy to reflect meaningful rate reductions, offering potential savings in the future. Refinancing could also expand mortgage eligibility for some buyers.

Banks are likely to aggressively promote refinancing in 2025, encouraging property owners to lower their EMIs. However, careful consideration of switching costs and market conditions is crucial. Refinancing is an attractive but complex option, particularly for those on variable-rate mortgages.

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Abu Dhabi schools told to help students at risk

Adek issues pointers to detect those with challenges

ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED

Abu Dhabi Editor

Schools in Abu Dhabi must now have a system in place to support students facing educational challenges.

The Department of Education and Knowledge in Abu Dhabi (Adek) has introduced a new policy that makes schools responsible for developing a mechanism for identifying such pupils and use intervention programmes.

Also, if a child is determined to be at risk due to mistreatment, schools must follow the procedures outlined in the Student Protection Policy of Adek. These steps should be confidential to protect the student's privacy and psychological well-being while addressing their needs.

Schools can use many

ways to help them recognise cases, such as family-related circumstances, academic or health assessments provided by the school with parental consent, academic performance, language difficulties, and frequent school transfers, among others.

Targeted teaching urged

If a student's situation is not improving because of the first set of interventions, they can be provided more targeted teaching to help them academically and align with behavioural goals. In fact, there are several levels of interventions – such as support from external specialists – which should be used as required.

SEE ALSO P2

Adek has introduced a new policy that makes schools responsible for developing a mechanism for identifying such pupils.

Tonino Lamborghini
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